

Build a Brand, Not a Listing

How independent properties reduce dependency on OTAs and Airbnb — and start owning their guests.

All-in, an OTA booking costs **22–28%** once you count commission, preferred-programme uplift, payment processing and campaign spend. On a first-time guest, that is fair acquisition cost. On a repeat guest, it is a tax you chose to pay.

What percentage of your repeat guests still book through an OTA?

Most owners have never calculated it. The answer is usually the size of the problem.

OWN THE GUEST

Your guest database. A property doing 3,000 room-nights a year has hosted 4,000–6,000 people and can usually reach fewer than 200 of them. OTAs withhold contact data by design — masked emails, platform-only messaging. Every lever below depends on closing that gap first, because loyalty has nobody to enrol and referral has nobody to ask until it is closed.

Digital pre-arrival check-in. The highest-leverage single change available to most properties. Sold to the guest as "skip the paperwork at the front desk," it captures every adult's details, consent, preferences and occasion before they arrive — turning a compliance chore you already perform into a marketing database. Guests complete it because it is genuinely convenient, and the front desk gains the context to personalise the stay.

WhatsApp as the primary channel. In India it outperforms email several times over on open and response rates. Booking support, pre-arrival upsells, post-stay follow-up and re-engagement all run through one thread the guest actually reads.

CAPTURE THE DEMAND YOU ALREADY CREATED

Branded search. Nobody books on first touch — they discover you on an OTA or Instagram, then Google your name to check you are real. That search is demand *you* created, and it currently converts on Booking.com because the OTAs outrank you on your own name. OTAs call this the billboard effect and cite it as proof of their value; it is the strongest argument against them.

Google Business Profile and free booking links. Google shows booking links in the hotel panel at no cost — but only if your booking engine is connected to it. If it is not, only OTAs appear, with no fallback. This is the biggest structural fix available and it costs close to nothing.

A booking engine that does not lose people. Mobile-first, three clicks, UPI and cards, no forced signup, embedded rather than redirecting to a third-party domain. A meaningful share of what looks like OTA dependency is simply a direct funnel that drops people at the last step.

Rate strategy and the book-direct stack. Never win on price — it breaches parity, trains guests to price-shop and erodes your rate permanently. Win on certainty, flexibility, inclusions and recognition: guaranteed best room, better cancellation terms, breakfast, late checkout, F&B credit. Worth 8–15% in perceived value at near-zero real cost, and entirely outside what parity clauses actually bind.

Direct-only inventory. Parity governs the price of a room type on a date; it does not oblige you to distribute every room. Keeping the best villa or suite off the OTAs is legitimate, and it gives guests a reason to book direct that no discount can match.

RETAIN AND MULTIPLY

Loyalty as stay credit. Points are opaque at independent scale and nobody trusts the conversion. Credit — earn a percentage back, spend it on your next stay, expires in twelve months — is understood instantly and forces a return visit. Member rates shown only to logged-in guests are the one legitimate route to pricing below the OTA without breaching your contracts.

Referral, asked at the right moment. Travel referral happens anyway — "where did you stay?" gets asked after every good trip. The programme's only job is making sure there is a link to send when it does. Two-sided reward, triggered on checkout day and immediately after a five-star review, paid out on the friend's completed stay.

Review architecture. Route post-stay review requests to Google, not the OTA. Same effort, but an OTA review strengthens their listing while a Google review strengthens an asset you own and lifts conversion on your own brand search.

Gift cards and prepaid credit. Cash upfront, a locked-in future guest, and a new person introduced to you by someone who already loves the place.

FILL THE TROUGH AND GENERATE NEW DEMAND

Community and young travel brand tie-ups. You do not have an occupancy problem, you have a trough problem — full on weekends, empty on Tuesday in July. Run clubs, surf schools, supper clubs, nomad communities and curated trip brands are the only demand source that is genuinely date-flexible, because the group is the reason for the trip. A thirty-person weekend is not one booking; it is thirty people entering your database.

B2B, offsites and groups. Highest ticket, zero commission, mid-week, booked weeks ahead with a deposit. Group ADR is lower but F&B attach is several times leisure, so total revenue per guest is usually higher — the number most owners get wrong when they turn group business away. Requires GST invoicing, credit terms and wifi that holds thirty people; those three block more deals than price ever does.

Social media as your top of funnel. Instagram and short-form video have replaced the OTA as the discovery layer for travellers under 35 — people find a place in a reel, save it, Google the name, then book. It is the only lever that creates demand rather than capturing it. Destination content reaches people who have not chosen anywhere yet; property content only converts people who already know you, so the mix matters more than the volume.

Turning reach into bookings. Most property accounts collect views and dead-end — the bio link points to Airbnb, or to nine options. One link straight to direct booking, comment-triggered DMs that capture a contact rather than just a click, and every conversation routed into WhatsApp and the guest database. Social should feed your CRM continuously, not produce screenshots.

Creator partnerships. Micro creators — ten to a hundred thousand followers — outperform large accounts on both trust and cost. Worth doing only with a contract: specified deliverables, a posting window, unique tracking codes, and perpetual usage rights so you can reuse the footage in your ads and on your site. Without that clause you have bought a free stay for a story that disappears in a day.

Experiences, F&B and day passes. Bring locals and non-guests into the brand's orbit. It builds an audience that exists independent of your room inventory, and gives people a reason to know you before they ever need a room.

Adjacent brand collaborations. Coffee roasters, outdoor gear, apparel, EV, luggage. Co-branded stays and giveaways put you in front of an audience someone else spent years building.

WHAT WE MEASURE

METRIC	TYPICAL TODAY	TARGET
Direct booking share	10–20%	35–50%
Contactable past guests	Under 5%	70%+
Repeat guest rate	Under 5%	15–25%
Cost per direct booking	Unmeasured	Well under OTA commission
Trough occupancy — mid-week, off-season	Unmeasured	The real scoreboard

Sequencing. Build from the bottom, sell from the top. Data capture first, then search and conversion, then retention, then demand generation. Social is the strongest demand engine you have — but most agencies switch it on first, pouring reach into a funnel that leaks at every stage below it.